



Judging Actions by Their Outcomes: An Introduction to Consequentialism

An original lesson plan inspired by **Walter Sinnott-Armstrong's** the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Consequentialism. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Walter Sinnott-Armstrong. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/consequentialism/>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Ethics

“If only consequences determine whether an action is right, does that mean any action — including lying, breaking a promise, or harming an innocent person — could be justified as long as it produces enough good?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Define consequentialism and distinguish it from deontological and virtue-based approaches to ethics.
- Differentiate act consequentialism from rule consequentialism and explain why the distinction matters for evaluating individual acts.
- Apply consequentialist reasoning to a contested case and identify the theory's strongest objection.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard or shared doc for recording votes and the comparison chart
- Printed case-study handout with the transplant surgeon scenario and a second variant
- Index cards for anonymous voting
- Blank comparison chart handout: consequentialism vs. deontology vs. virtue ethics

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Transplant Surgeon

10 min

Present the classic case: a surgeon could secretly kill one healthy visitor to harvest organs and save five dying patients, with certainty of not being caught. Have students vote anonymously on an index card whether this would be permissible, and collect a rough tally without discussion. Tell them you'll return to this vote at the end of class.

Direct Instruction: What Makes an Action Right?

15 min

Define consequentialism as the view that an act's rightness depends solely on its consequences, weighed impartially across everyone affected — not on the actor's motives, the nature of the act itself, or any rule it breaks. Introduce the distinction between act consequentialism (evaluate each individual act by its own consequences) and rule consequentialism (follow the rule whose general adoption produces the best consequences). Keep this brief and vocabulary-focused.

Small-Group Case Analysis

15 min

In small groups, students apply both act and rule consequentialism to the transplant case and a second case (e.g., a doctor considering whether to lie to a terminally ill patient to preserve their hope). Each group records what act consequentialism recommends versus what rule consequentialism recommends, noting any cases where the two come apart.

Whole-Class Discussion: Objections

14 min

Surface the theory's major objections: that it can justify violating an individual's rights whenever doing so maximizes overall welfare (the 'separateness of persons' objection), that it may be too demanding by requiring impartial concern for strangers, and that predicting all downstream consequences of an act is often practically impossible. Ask which objection students find most damaging.

Closure: The Re-Vote

6 min

Have students vote anonymously again on the transplant case. Reveal both tallies and ask a few students what, if anything, changed their reasoning. Close by naming the central tension the lesson explored: outcomes matter, but do they matter enough to override everything else?

Discussion Questions

- 1 Does rule consequentialism actually escape the objections against act consequentialism, or does it collapse back into act consequentialism whenever breaking the rule would produce better consequences in a particular case?
- 2 If consequentialism requires treating everyone's happiness impartially, does it ask too much of ordinary people by requiring them to weigh a stranger's welfare as equally important as their own family's?
- 3 Is the transplant case a fair test of consequentialism, or does it stack the deck by ignoring long-term consequences like the erosion of trust in doctors and hospitals?
- 4 Can consequentialism account for the intuition that some actions, like framing an innocent person, are wrong even when they produce better overall outcomes?
- 5 Whose happiness counts, and how would we ever reliably measure and compare it across different people?

Assessment

Students write a short position paper (350–500 words) evaluating the transplant surgeon case from a consequentialist standpoint, explicitly considering both act and rule consequentialist reasoning, and stating whether they find the consequentialist verdict persuasive or whether it reveals a weakness in the theory. Grade for accurate application of both versions of the theory and engagement with at least one objection, not for which conclusion the student reaches.

Extension Activity

Have students find a real policy debate (e.g., a proposed surveillance law or a public health mandate) where advocates explicitly justify the policy by appeal to overall outcomes, and write a short analysis distinguishing the act-consequentialist argument being made from any rule-consequentialist alternative, along with one objection a rights-based critic would raise.

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